PRD: Elite Tokens and Social Ladder (Short)

Oct 13, 2026 · @Mainak Sarkar · Condensed from the full v2.0 PRD

1. Overview

Elite Tokens are one in-app currency with two jobs: diners spend them on Elite features, and every Token earned counts toward their social ladder rank. Goals: more repeat Partner visits, Elite payments, experiences and curations, plus an earned rank that signals credibility, not spend.

Two counters. Token Balance buys features and falls with spending, expiry and reversals. **Lifetime Tokens (LT)**, shown as **Status XP**, sets the level and falls only on reversals. Purchased Tokens, Creator grants and the starter allowance never count toward LT.

Targets: a new tier every 1–3 months early on · 70–85% of issued Tokens spent or expired within 6 months · payment-linked Tokens ⩽ 40% of LT.

Constraints: can be bought in packs but not transferred, withdrawn or cashed out; free Tokens funded by Explorex; per-Token rupee value shown only in the store. Every number here is an admin-configurable default, applied prospectively.

2. Earning

A Partner visit paid through Elite with a verified experience earns about 220 Tokens; without Elite payment, about 100. All rewards stack.

- **Qualifying Partner visit** (diner's share ⩾ ₹500): 40 · max 1 per restaurant per day, 2 per day
- **Elite payment** ₹500 / ₹1,000 / ₹2,000 / ₹3,500+: 40 / 80 / 120 / 150 · max 2 per day
- **Experiences:** verified Partner 60 (1 per visit) · verified non-partner 40 (8/month) · unverified full 15 (3 per 7 days, 8/month)
- **Qualifying curation:** 150 · 2/month
- **Received engagement:** helpful 2, save 2, follow 5 · 200/month
- **Monthly regular bonus** (3+ Partner visits at 2+ restaurants): 100 · **First-time milestones:** 50 each

Flat payment tiers avoid a cashback reading. Content rewards are PENDING until moderation (< 24h), payments until settlement; verification upgrades pay the difference. Placeholder calibration: casual ~230/month, regular ~940, power ~2,170 (replace with cohort data before pilot).

3. Wallet

- **Active from day 1:** every confirmed Token is spendable immediately and counts toward LT. No activation step, no locked state.
- **Starter allowance:** 75 Tokens on the first full experience (not on sign-up), for AI tools and Elara only; not counted in LT.
- **Creator grant:** approved Creators get 1,000 spendable Tokens on the 1st of each month (prorated on approval). Not counted in LT, no rollover (expires when the next grant lands), removed if Creator status is revoked. Shown as its own line: *"Creator Tokens: 640 left, refresh on 1 Nov."*
- **Spending order:** Creator grant, then starter allowance, then earned Tokens oldest first.
- **Expiry:** earned Tokens expire 6 months after confirmation. Expired Tokens still count in LT. Reminders at 30 and 7 days. Permanent unlocks never expire.
- **Buying Tokens:** 500 for ₹49 · 1,250 for ₹99 · 2,750 for ₹199 · 7,500 for ₹499 · 16,000 for ₹999 (incl. GST). Spendable immediately, spent last, no expiry, never count toward Status XP, no refunds (store refunds reverse them). In-app purchase on iOS/Android, own gateway on web; ₹5,000/day cap. Not usable on Amplify pending D-P1, since a ₹999 pack would undercut restaurant memberships.

4. Spending

Prices are set so a regular diner spends about 75% of what they earn. Basic Elara chat and discovery stay free; nothing spends without an explicit tap, and failed actions release their Tokens.

- **AI (L1):** title 10 · improve narration 20 · Write with AI 30 · curation description 30
- **Elara:** shortlist 40, comparison 60, menu analysis 60 (L1) · occasion plan 100, celebration plan 150, group decision 150 (Explorer, L4)
- **Amplify (everyone):** Quick 150 (3 days, 250 impressions) · Momentum 350 (7 days, 750) · Spotlight 700 (14 days, 2,000)
- **Identity:** app icon 600 (L4) · curation cover 120, theme pack 900 (L7) · monthly limited icon 1,500 (L10) · animated curator badge 1,500 (L16) · identity pack 2,500 (L22)

Amplify: any diner can Amplify any eligible experience, including *Not Worth It* right after posting. No refunds; under 90% delivery at window end auto-extends. Full rules in the Amplify engineering spec.

Burn without loss: status shown first, *"Your status is unchanged"* after each spend, refill cue under 100, a pinned saving goal, one limited drop a month. Finance sets a Token-funded cost ceiling per diner.

5. Social ladder and Status XP

Every earned Token adds 1 Status XP. Levels are open-ended; every three share a tier name, shown as *Tastemaker II · Level 14*.

Tier · levels · Status XP per level · gate to enter · when a regular diner gets there:

- **Newcomer** 1–3 · 0 / 75 / 150 · day 1
- **Explorer** 4–6 · 200 / 375 / 550 · ~1 week
- **Regular** 7–9 · 700 / 1,050 / 1,400 · ~3 weeks
- **Insider** 10–12 · 1,800 / 2,350 / 2,900 · ~2 months
- **Tastemaker** 13–15 · 3,500 / 4,500 / 5,500 · 5 full experiences · ~4 months
- **Curator** 16–18 · 6,500 / 8,000 / 9,500 · 10 verified, 1 curation · ~7 months
- **Connoisseur** 19–21 · 11,000 / 13,500 / 16,000 · 20 verified, 3 curations · ~12 months
- **Trendsetter** 22–24 · 18,000 / 21,500 / 25,000 · 35 verified, 6 curations, 150 engagements · ~19 months
- **Elite Icon** 25–27 · 28,000 / 32,500 / 37,000 · 55 verified, 10 curations, 400 engagements · ~30 months
- **Elite Legend** 28–30 · 42,000 / 47,000 / 52,000 · 80 verified, 15 curations, 1,000 engagements · ~45 months; then +1 level per 6,000 XP with no cap, while Active
- **Gates** apply only on entering a tier. A diner blocked by a gate holds at the top of their tier and jumps straight to the right level once it's met.
- **XP never earned from:** purchased Tokens, starter allowance, Creator grant, Amplify impressions, fake or self-engagement, PENDING Tokens.
- **XP only falls on reversals** (refunds, removed content, fake engagement, fraud), with an in-app notice naming the cause. Spending, expiry and inactivity never lower it.
- **Active status:** a badge is Active if the diner earned 300+ Tokens in the last 60 days, otherwise muted. Levels are never lost to inactivity.
- **Display:** own profile shows exact XP, progress and any unmet gate; others see tier and level only. Tier-ups get a full-screen moment and a shareable card. Level is a trust signal, not a feed-ranking boost. No leaderboards in MVP.
- **Guardrail:** if payment XP exceeds 40% of total XP across active diners for two months, payment tiers are reviewed.

6. Edge cases and fraud controls

- **Reversal after spending:** balance may go negative; spending is blocked until future earnings repay it. LT drops regardless. Written off and reviewed after 12 months.

- **Refunds:** full refund reverses payment Tokens and the visit reward if it no longer qualifies, and downgrades the linked experience; partial refund re-tiers the payment.
- **Group dining:** each linked diner with a ≥ ₹500 share gets the visit reward; payers get payment Tokens on what they paid.
- **Content:** deleted within 30 days or removed by moderation → reversed; curations broken within 30 days → reversed. Partner status at visit time applies.
- **Fraud:** unique bill IDs and daily caps; settled payments only; originality and duplicate checks; receipt forensics; ring, bot and device-farm detection; ON_HOLD freezes spending and levels.

7. Data, events and admin

- **Ledger:** one append-only `token_ledger` is the source of truth for Balance and LT (entry types earn, grant, spend, reverse, expire, adjust; `counts_to_lifetime` flag). Wallet and status counters are caches reconciled nightly. Full schema in the long PRD.
- **States:** PENDING, AVAILABLE, RESERVED, SPENT, RELEASED, REVERSED, EXPIRED, ON_HOLD. One idempotency key per reward; atomic reservation for spending. A Token outage never blocks restaurant payment.
- **Admin (logged, reason required):** all values, caps and thresholds; catalogue and drops; Creator grant; issuance and spending pauses; manual adjustments; fraud holds.

8. Metrics, rollout and scope

Pilot targets vs control: repeat Partner visits +10% · experiences per active diner +25% · Elite payment share +5 pts · burn 70–85% · payment share of LT ≤ 40% · median time to Tastemaker 3–5 months · first spend within 30 days ≥ 40%. **Guardrails:** cost under the finance ceiling, no drop in *Not Worth It* share, quality no worse than control, reversals < 3%.

Rollout: internal testing (3–4 weeks) → 90-day pilot with city-cluster holdouts → tune → expand after one full cycle and 30 clean days of reconciliation. **Out of MVP:** transferring or cashing Tokens; restaurant-funded Tokens; level multipliers; paid level advancement.

Open questions: D-P1 (purchased Tokens on Amplify) · cost ceiling · cohort data · Elara readiness · legal, GST and DPDP review · Partner visibility in Bridge OS · Creator grant cap on Amplify. Acceptance criteria are in the full PRD.